

SPACE-TIME CONTINUUM

THE STORIES IN THIS SCI-FI ANTHOLOGY MIGHT BE SET IN THE FUTURE, BUT THEIR ROOTS ARE IN THE HERE AND NOW

First, a quibble: why on earth is the type so small? A book this ambitious, surely deserves a larger font size. Because, once you're over that particular hurdle, this is a rewarding volume.

I'm not a habitual reader of science fiction. Still, this collection spoke to me, and its major strength is tied root and branch to its ambition. This is not an 'Indian' collection. It is truly South Asian and deserves all the flowers it will surely get for bringing those disparate flavours together. *If* the speculative worlds of authors are rooted in the 'realities' they inhabit, then surely casting the net wide can only be a good thing. Nor are all these South Asians currently residing in their lands of origin. To me, the bios at the end were just as interesting as the stories themselves.

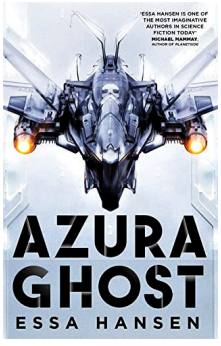
The editor, Tarun Saint, is to be commended for his curation. He frontloads a couple of strong stories: 'And Now His Lordship is Laughing' by Shiv Ramdas and 'The Traveller' by Tashan Mehta lay down strong markers. The middle doesn't sag, either: 'A Different Sea' by Vandana Singh and 'The List' by Gautam Bhatia are standouts. But it is at the end, where a reader's interest might flag, that this collection truly shines. Usman Malik's 'Resurrection Points', a harrowing tale of religious strife and the dead being brought to life in Pakistan, gives way to 'Shambhala' by Salik Shah, a meditation on childhood and exile against the backdrop of the Chinese occupation of Tibet, which in turn is followed by Yudhanyaja Wijeratne's 'Confessor', set in a black hole of a prison cell in a Sri Lanka that isn't of our time, but can only too easily be imagined. Saad Z. Hossain's brilliant 'Bring Your Own Spoon', set in Dhaka's ruined 'fringe' and featuring a vagrant chef and an insignificant djinn, is the perfect ending.

Dystopian, you say? Well, of course. Truth is stranger than fiction, we are told, and we only need to look around to see how immediate all these scenarios are. None of these authors shy away from the big themes: among other

MY BEST OF 2021



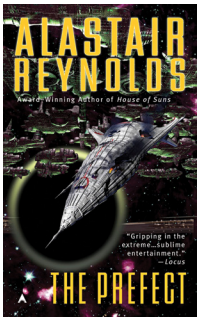
GAUTAM BHATIA
Author, The Wall



AZURA GHOST
by Essa Hansen
ORBIT
₹494 (KINDLE); 512 pages

The sequel to *Nophek Gloss*, *Azura Ghost* is due to be formally published in March 2022, and marks the continuation of one of the most innovative and original contemporary space operas available today. Hansen's "multiverse"—with its many species—is deeply visual, engagingly complex, and, like the best science fiction, sets up all the great questions without doing its readers the disservice of too-easy answers.

THE PREFECT
by Alastair Reynolds
ACE
₹900; 576 pages



Reynold's futuristic space opera, set around the many worlds of the 'Glitter Band', whose denizens all engage in a form of direct democracy to make decisions, often felt like a cross between the best of Iain M. Banks (in the moral stakes that it set up) and more recent science fiction detective stories, such as Emma Newman's *After Atlas*. Here is a rare work of science fiction that makes the practice of democracy one of its central plot points.